portfolio.

teaching.

mojtaba ashour.
2023-2026

DEA 1100

Cornell University

Summer 2026

Keywords:
Design Thinking
Studio Pedagogy
Prototyping
Human-Centered Design

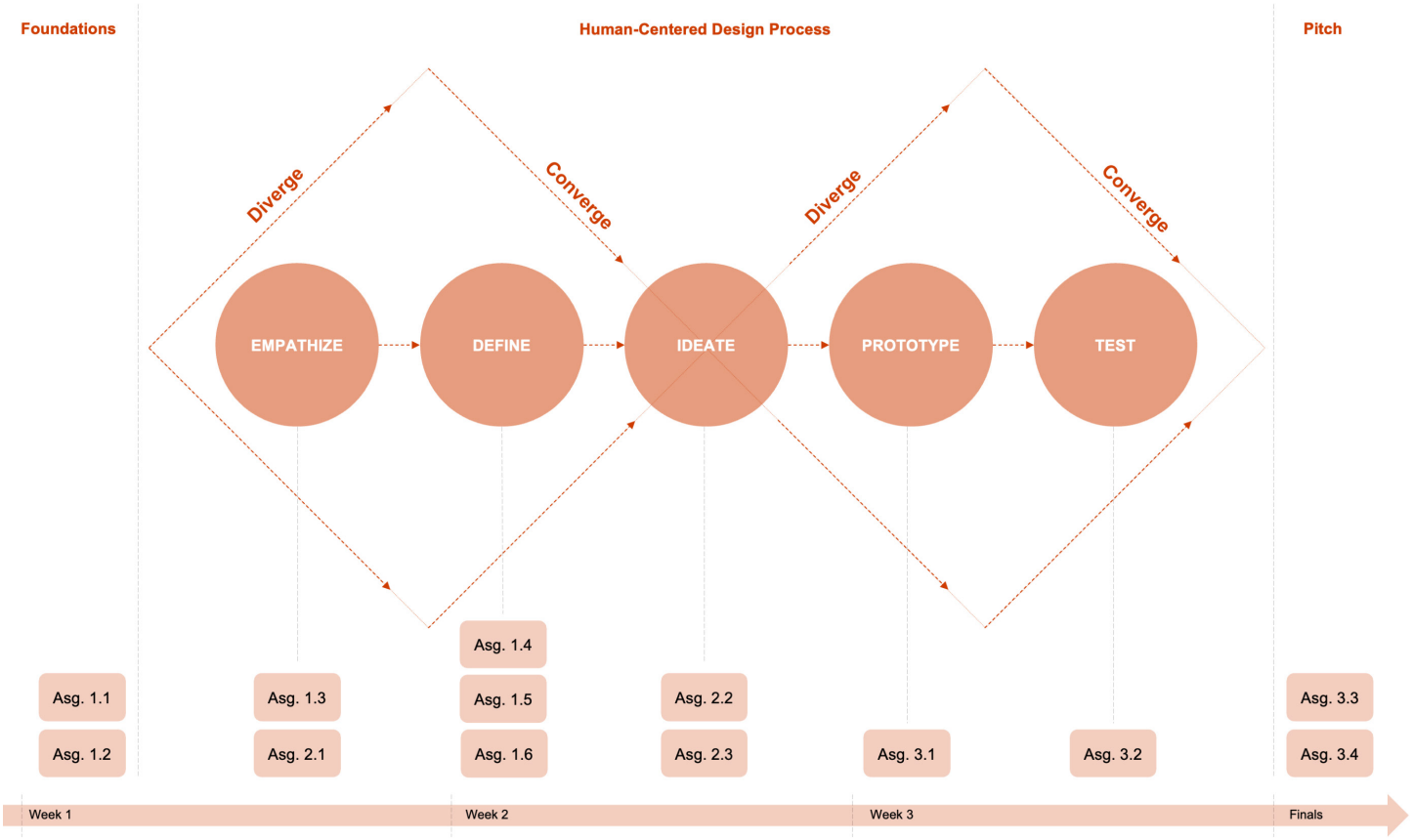
Human Centered Design
Cornell Human Ecology

Design Generation(s) Studio

Instructor of Record: **Mojtaba Ashour**

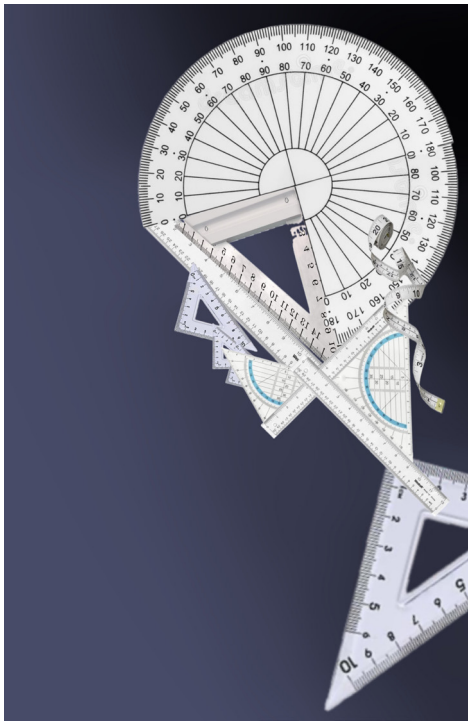
DEA 1100: Design Generation(s) is a three-week precollege studio that introduces high school students to how designers think, solve problems, and shape a more human-centered future. Students build skills in sketching, modeling, prototyping, and visual communication while exploring fields such as architecture, interior, urban, UX, product, and graphic design. Short individual exercises build the foundation for a group design thinking project that moves from applied environmental and behavioral research to problem definition, ideation, prototyping, testing, and a final design pitch.

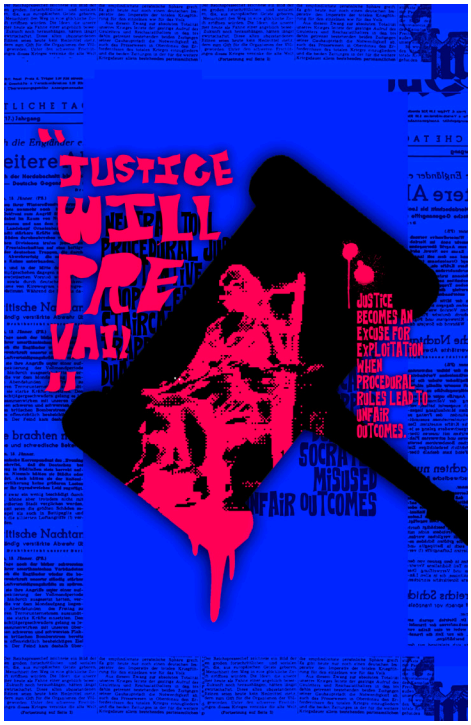
The course runs as a daily studio built on pin-ups, critiques, and revision, so students learn to present, defend, and improve their work. Guest lectures from Cornell faculty and industry partners link studio work to real practice. Grading rewards process as much as product, with creative exercises at 35 percent, the team project at 40 percent, and participation and attendance at 25 percent. Students rated the course 4.87/5 for fostering a sense of belonging.



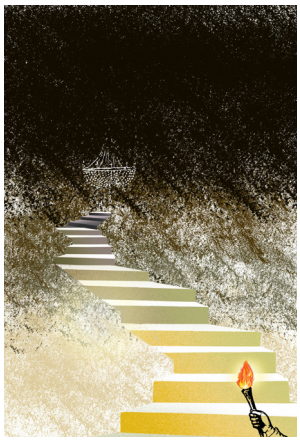
Assignments mapped to the human-centered design process across the three-week DEA 1100 studio, from foundations to the final pitch.

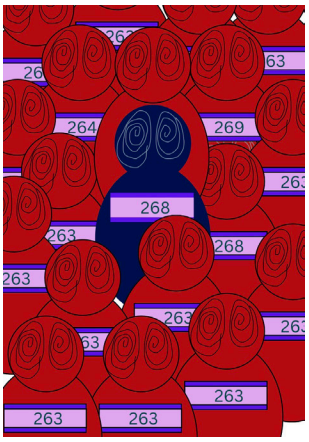






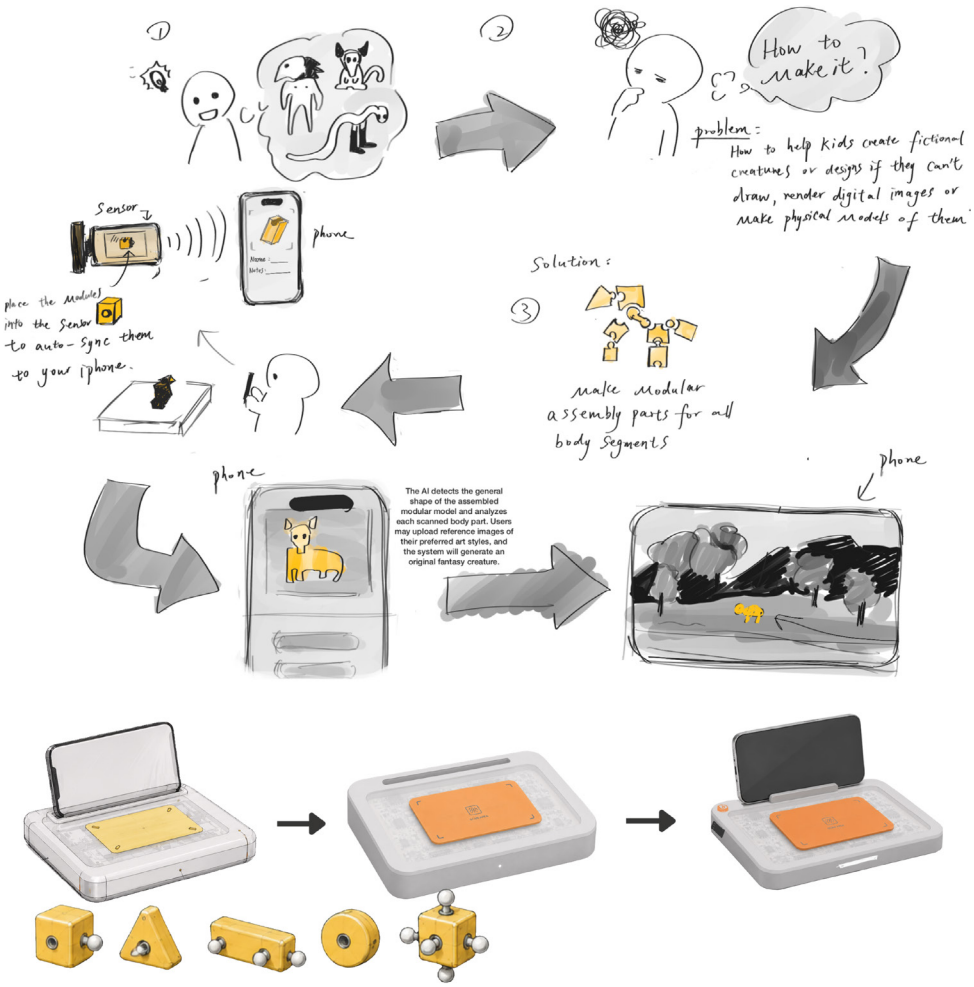






Assignment 1.2:

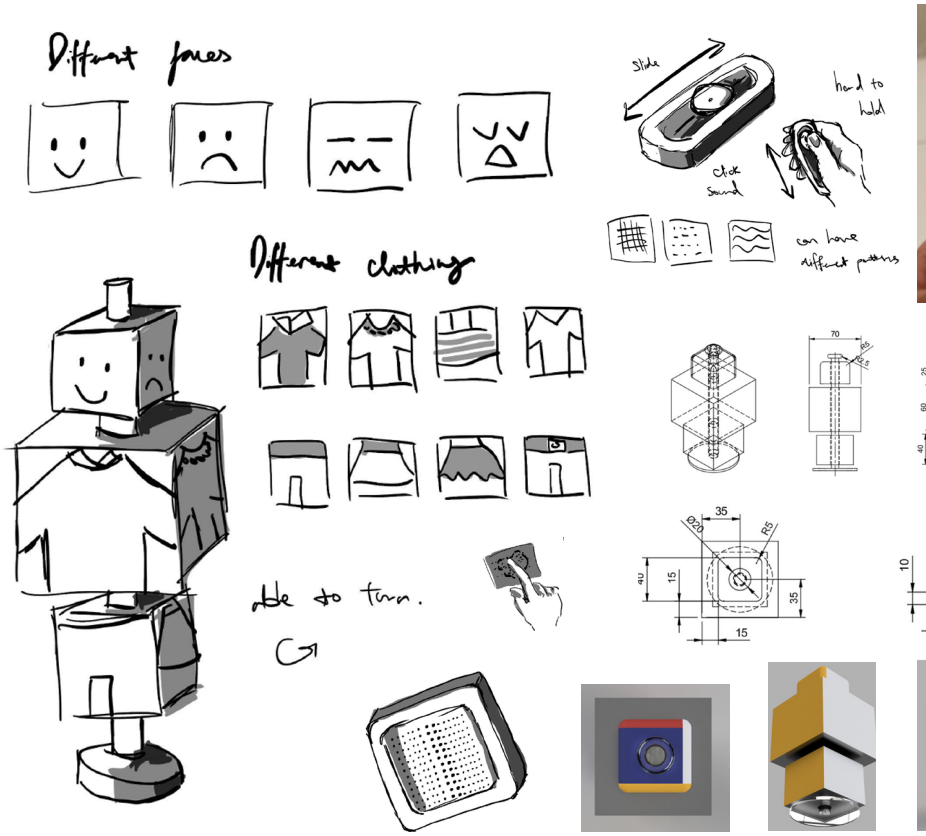
Visual identity posters asked students to translate a personal life value into a clear graphic statement with minimal text. The goal was to communicate the essence of the value, not to make a poster about themselves. At the pin-up, students presented their sketches next to the final print and received peer feedback. Examples are from the Summer 2026 studio.

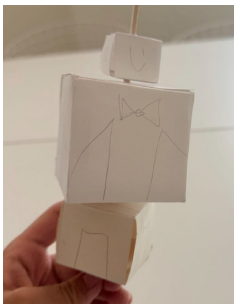




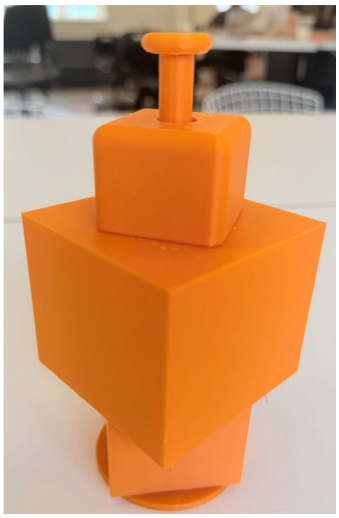
Assignment 1.3:

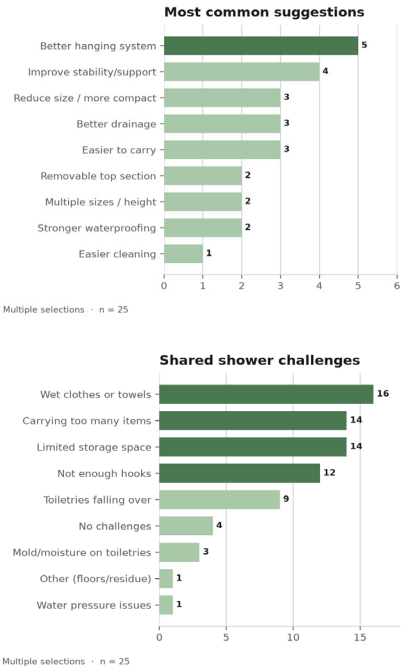
Human-Centered Toy Design Challenge asked students to define a user need, develop a toy concept, and show the process. Each student interviewed a friend or sibling, drew out insights, sketched three concepts, and built a low-fidelity prototype. The top project answers a quiet user's need for a calm, portable toy with a stacking figure that has swappable faces and clothing. Morphi, at the bottom, lets a user who can't draw build creatures from modular pieces that a scanning base turns into a digital character. Examples from the Summer 2026 studio.





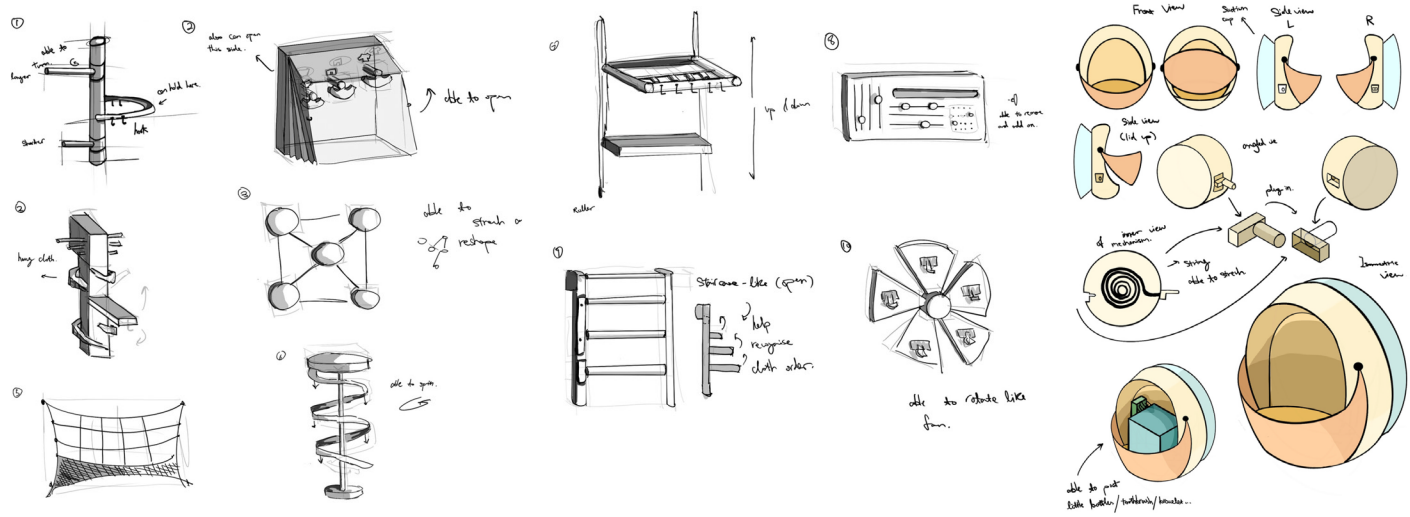


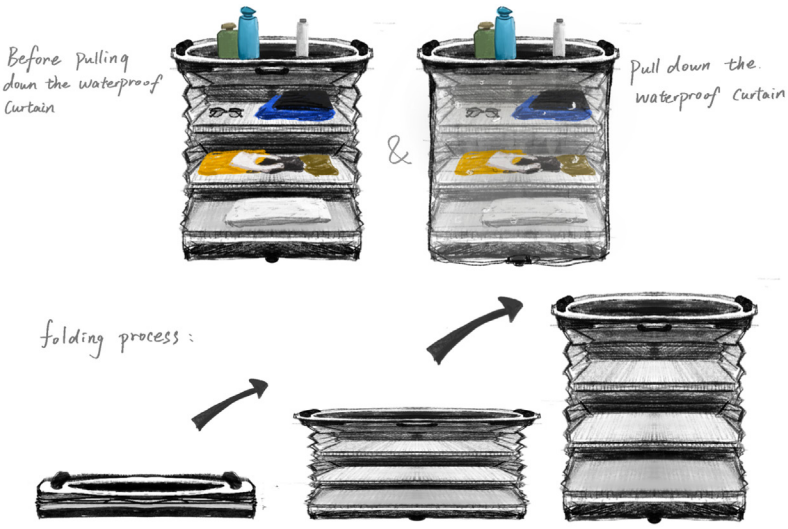






The team project began with empathy. In **Assignment 2.1**, one Summer 2026 team observed and surveyed their peers about the dorm shower experience. In **Assignments 1.4 and 1.5**, they mapped the full journey from packing to leaving and named pain points such as wet clothes, limited storage, and awkward carrying. The research framed the problem before any solution was drawn.





In **Assignments 2.2 and 2.3**, ideation moved through several rounds of sketches, structure studies, folding concepts, and early prototypes. When an idea failed in use or clarity, the team went back to the drawing board instead of polishing a weak direction, treating iteration as a design skill. Examples from the Summer 2026 studio.











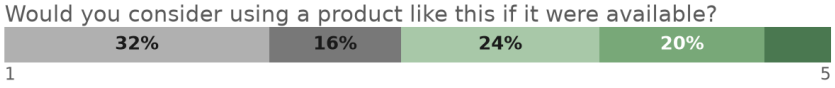
Prototype feedback

Ratings on a 1–5 scale · n = 25

How useful do you think this product would be for dorm students?



Would you consider using a product like this if it were available?



After seeing the prototype, how easy is it to understand how it works?



In **Assignment 3.1**, the team built a final prototype that showed the form, the folding sequence, and how the product solves the problem they researched. In **Assignment 3.2**, they tested it with potential users and read the feedback, so the proposal was judged on clarity and usefulness, not only on how finished it looked. **Assignments 3.3 and 3.4** closed the studio with a brand identity and a pitch that sold the idea. Examples from the Summer 2026 studio.

DEA 2203

Cornell University
Spring 2026

Keywords:
Design Studio
Concept Development
AI-Assisted Ideation
Critique

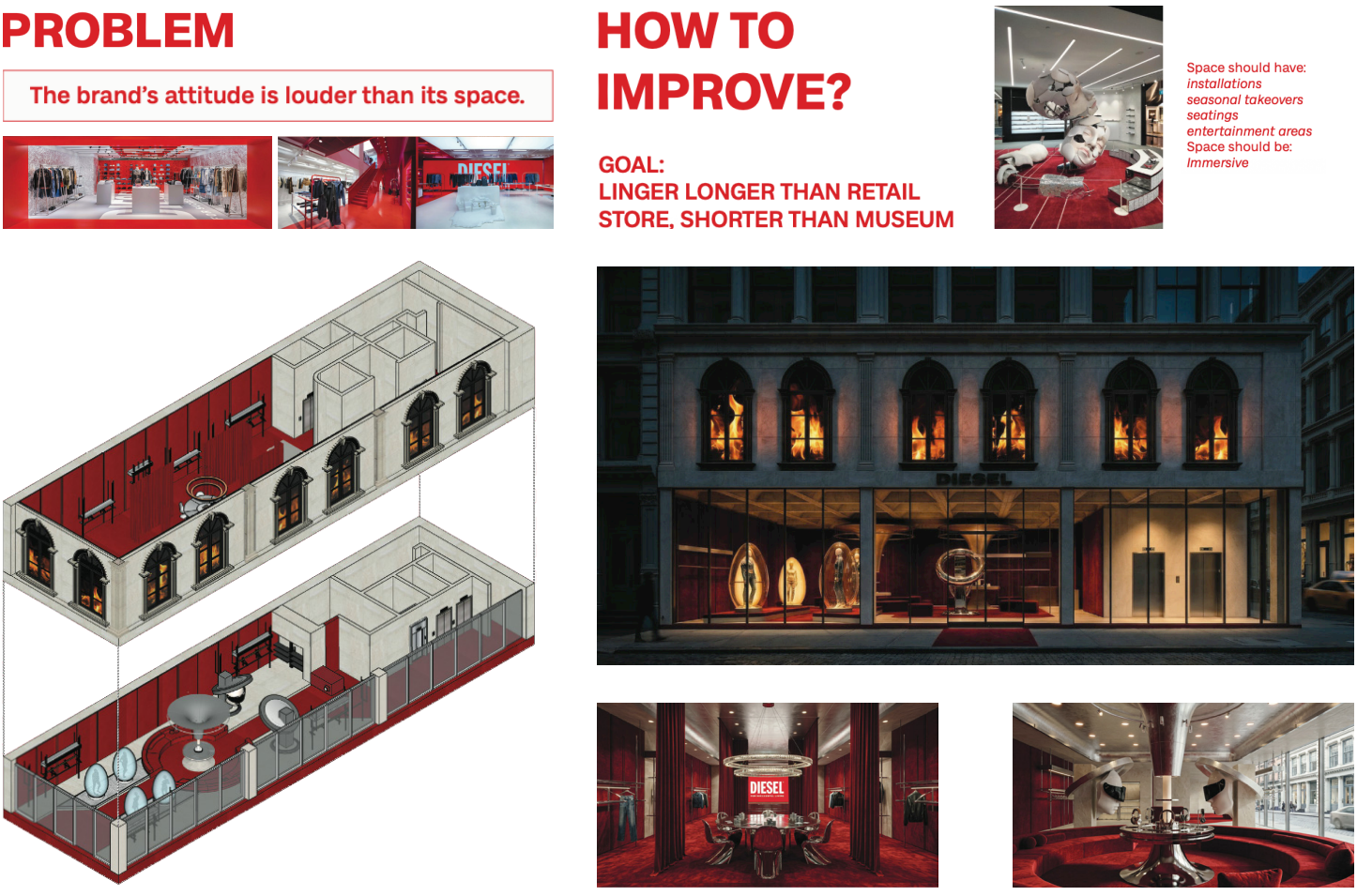
Human Centered Design
Cornell Human Ecology

Studio SHIFT

Instructor: Stephanie Lee
Teaching Assistant: **Mojtaba Ashour**

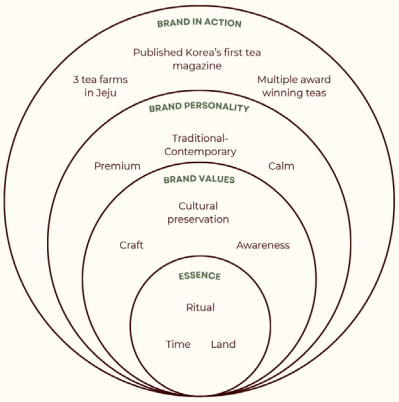
Studio SHIFT is an exploratory interior design studio about how space communicates identity and shapes experience through adaptive design. The semester opens with an individual immersive brand-experience project, in which students translate brand values into spatial organization, materiality, and lighting for a speculative SoHo retail interior. It ends with a collaborative campus partnership, where students act as design consultants redesigning the entry and arrival sequence for Cornell's Beebe Hall MakerHub.

I contributed to developing the assignment structure and the main project brief for 13 students, conducted regular desk crits and written feedback, and led class sessions independently, including lectures and a workshop on AI tools for early concept development. My role was to guide the story students tell: steering them toward a strong concept early, then helping them carry that narrative through the rest of the semester. Every student received detailed written feedback on their presentations and boards, tailored to their concept, drawings, and delivery.



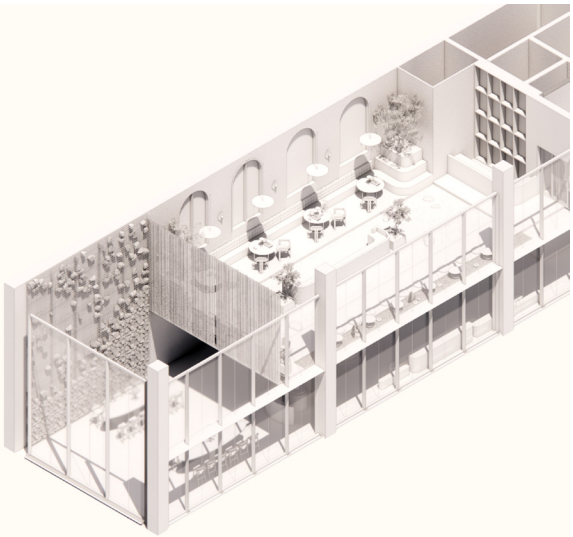
Project 1, Experiential Retail Design, asked each student to choose a brand, research its identity, find where its current spaces fall short of that identity, and design an immersive SoHo retail interior that turns the brand's values into spatial organization, materiality, and lighting. Example student submission from Spring 2026.

BRAND IDENTITY

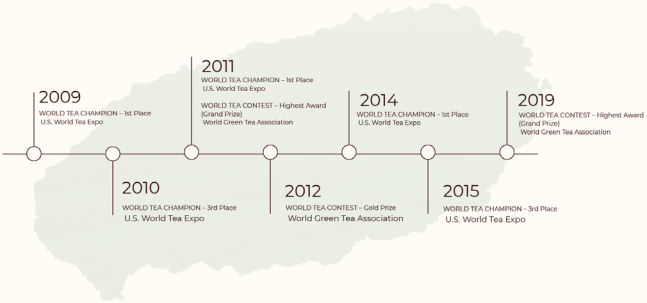


EMOTIONAL EXPERIENCE

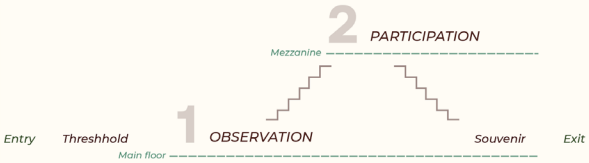
calm



BRAND ACCOMPLISHMENTS



SPATIAL STRATEGY



SITE & SCALE



TARGET AUDIENCE

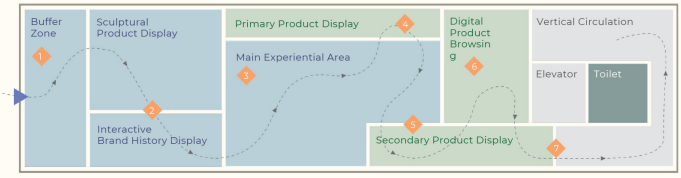
PRIMARY
Modern consumers seeking wellness-oriented lifestyles

SECONDARY
Domestic and international tourists

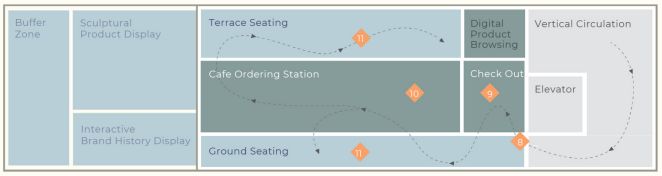
ASPIRATIONAL
Global consumers interested in premium Korean tea

BLOCKING DIAGRAM - USER

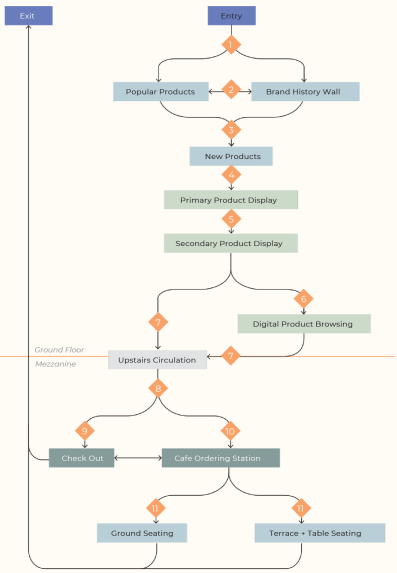
GROUND FLOOR



MEZZANINE



SPATIAL EXPERIENCE FLOWCHART

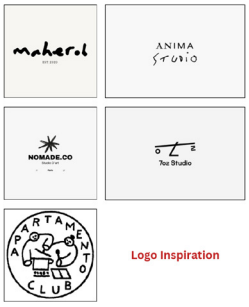


In **Project 1**, research came before form. Students studied each brand's values, audience, and emotional intent, then used those findings to guide early spatial decisions in blocking diagrams, user flow, and zoned floor plans. Example student submission from Spring 2026.

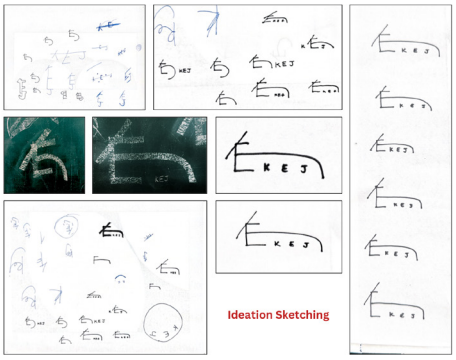
Experiential Zones | Product / Retail | Support / Service | Vertical Circulation | Main Entrance | Main Checkpoints | Circulation Pathway

KEJ Studio

"Krafted, Expressive, Joyful
— KEJ builds spaces that work hard and feel good, because function without warmth is just furniture."



Logo Inspiration


Ideation Sketching



Primary

Maya Chen

First-Year Student

New to making. Needs a friendly place to start.

Goals

- Know the space is beginner-friendly
- See where to start
- Feel comfortable returning

USER JOURNEY

STAGES	PRE-VISIT		VISIT		POST-VISIT
	Finding the Destination	Approaching the Entry	At the Threshold	Orienting Inside	Leaving with Confidence
EMOTIONAL NEEDS	Curious but unsure as the path to Beebe Hall feels more secluded.		Feels hesitant entering an unfamiliar space but becomes curious when seeing activity inside.		Feels encouraged and more confident about returning to use the space.
PRACTICAL NEEDS	Needs clear visual cues and markers that identify the Maker Hub from the wooded path.		Needs a clear "start here" moment that explains what the space is and how it works.		Needs a simple understanding of how to return and use the space again.



Secondary

Ethan Park

The Everyday User

Experienced user. Wants fast, direct access.

Goals

- Reach the right zone fast
- Find tools quickly
- Move easily between spaces

USER JOURNEY

STAGES	PRE-VISIT		VISIT		POST-VISIT
	Finding the Destination	Approaching the Entry	At the Threshold	Orienting Inside	Leaving with Confidence
EMOTIONAL NEEDS	Wants confidence that he is heading to the right place without losing time.		Wants to understand the layout quickly so he can reach the right making zone.		Wants to leave feeling that the space supports smooth, repeat use.
PRACTICAL NEEDS	Needs clear wayfinding and early identity cues that confirm the Maker Hub.		Needs the threshold and stair sequence to feel open, readable, and easy to move through.		Needs a clear mental map of the space so future visits feel faster and easier.



Tertiary

Prof. Elena Ramirez

Visiting Faculty Member

First-time visitor. Needs a clear and welcoming entry.

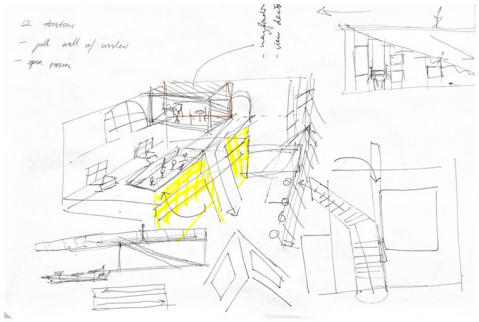
Goals

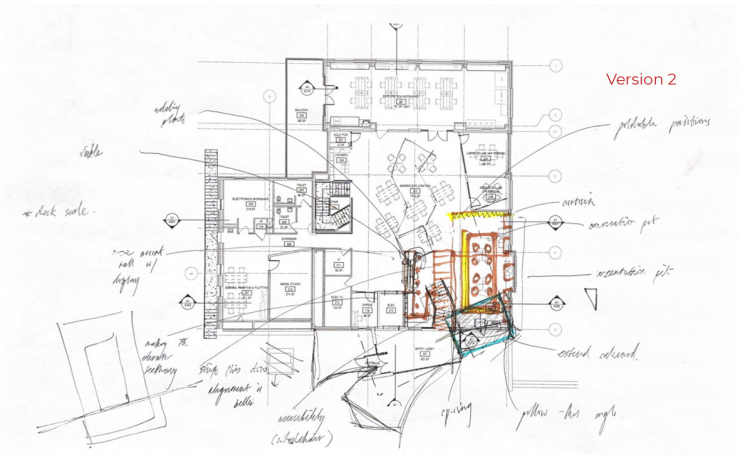
- Find the Maker Hub easily
- Meet others at a clear entry point
- Understand the space quickly

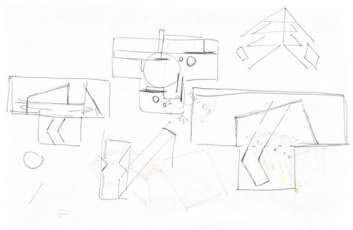
USER JOURNEY

STAGES	PRE-VISIT		VISIT		POST-VISIT
	Finding the Destination	Approaching the Entry	At the Threshold	Orienting Inside	Leaving with Confidence
EMOTIONAL NEEDS	Wants to feel welcomed, not hidden or out of place.		Needs calm orientation before moving deeper into the building.		Wants to leave feeling informed and welcomed.
PRACTICAL NEEDS	Recognize Beebe Hall from the main campus approach.		Understand programs, destinations, and spatial organization.		Leave with a clear mental map and return confidence.

Project 2, the Beebe Hall MakerHub partnership, began with user research. Teams built personas and journey maps for beginners, experienced makers, and first-time visitors to understand how each group arrives and finds their way in. Each team also created its own studio brand, treating its identity as part of the client experience rather than an afterthought beside the space. Example student group submission from Spring 2026.







Iteration Sketches



Version 1



Version 3







In **Project 2**, design development moved through iterative sketches, revised floor plans, and material studies before each team settled on a direction. Teams used AI-assisted 3D rendering to test spatial atmosphere quickly and show it to the client, so concepts could be judged visually as well as through diagrams. Example student group submission from Spring 2026.

DEA 4050

Cornell University
Fall 2023

Keywords:
Portfolio Narrative
Visual Identity
Critique
Professional Practice
Graphic Communication

Human Centered Design
Cornell Human Ecology

Design Portfolio and Communication Studio

Instructor: Nooshin Ahmadi
Teaching Assistant: **Mojtaba Ashour**

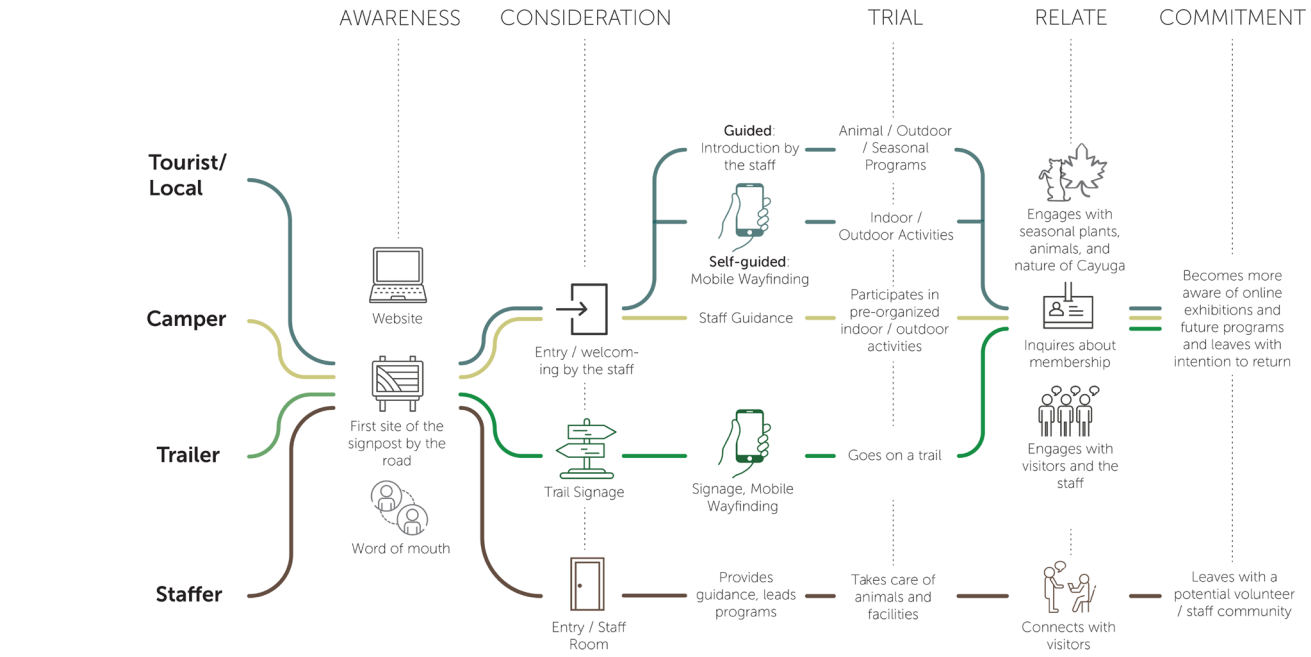
Design Portfolio and Communication teaches students to find their own story before they design their portfolios. Early identity diagrams and posters ask each student to name a personal narrative and express it visually. The course then moves into graphic systems, layout, branding, infographics, and website design, always asking whether the pages communicate clearly and whether the sequence reads as one coherent professional identity. Throughout, the emphasis stays on consistency, coherence, and visual communication.

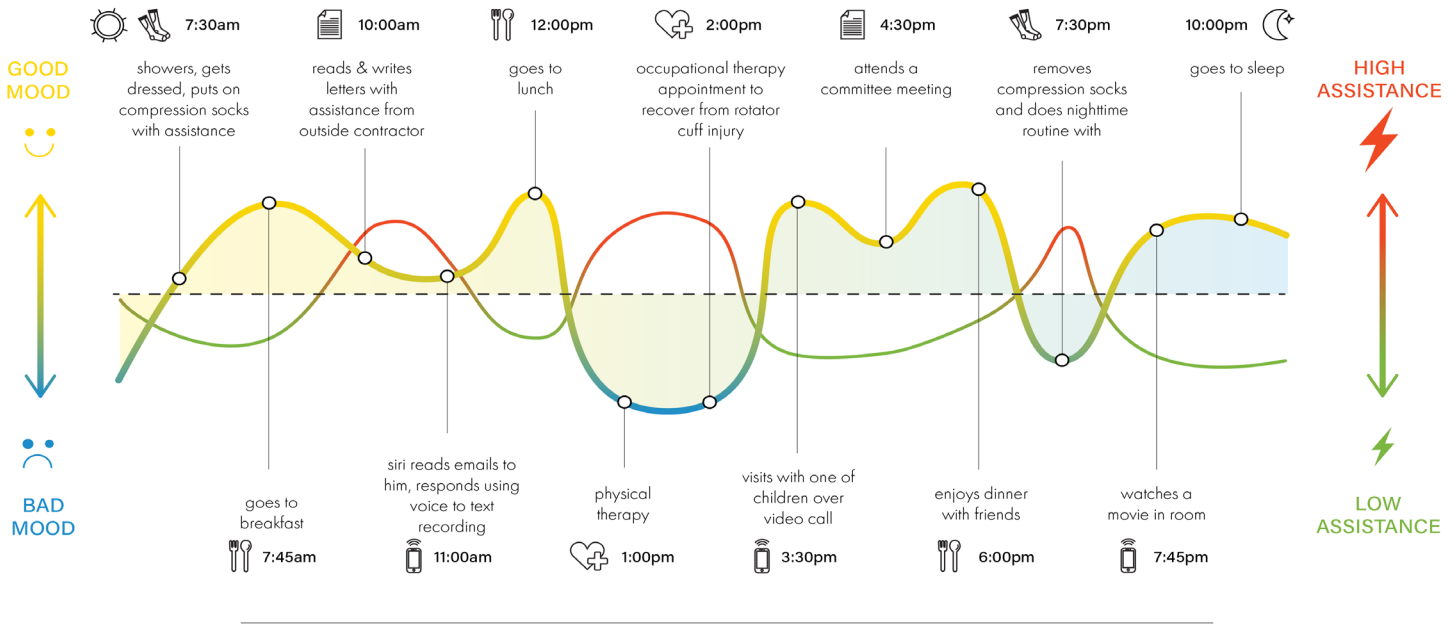
As teaching assistant for 17 senior students, I helped each one turn scattered coursework into a portfolio that told a single, coherent, and clear story. Through desk crits, written feedback, and office hours, students learned to make sense of their own work, sequence it with intent, and let visuals carry the narrative. Workshops I led in Adobe InDesign gave them the production skills to build that story themselves. Every student finished with a print portfolio and a website, and many used them to land their first design jobs.

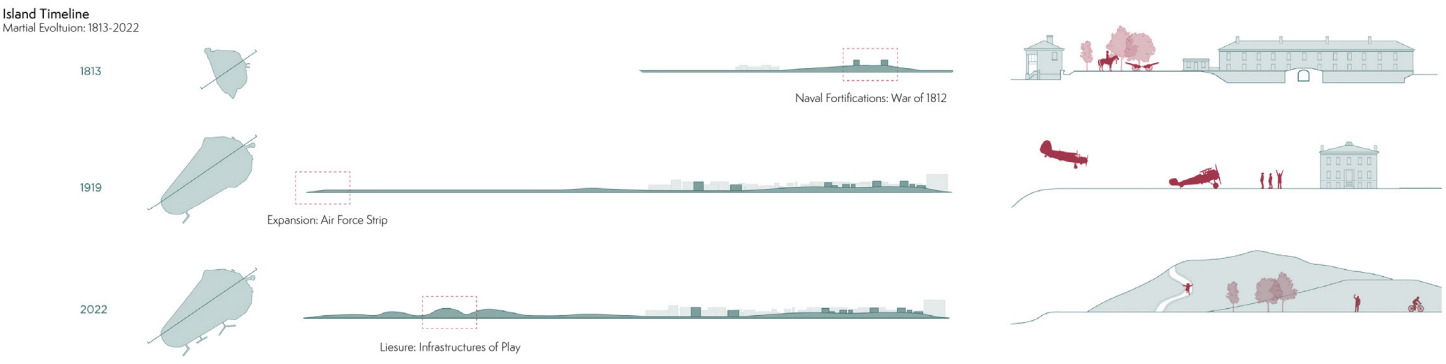




Before building their portfolios, students made identity posters and diagrams that named a personal narrative and expressed it visually, with as little text as possible. This early step gave each portfolio a clear story to organize around. Example student submissions from Fall 2023.







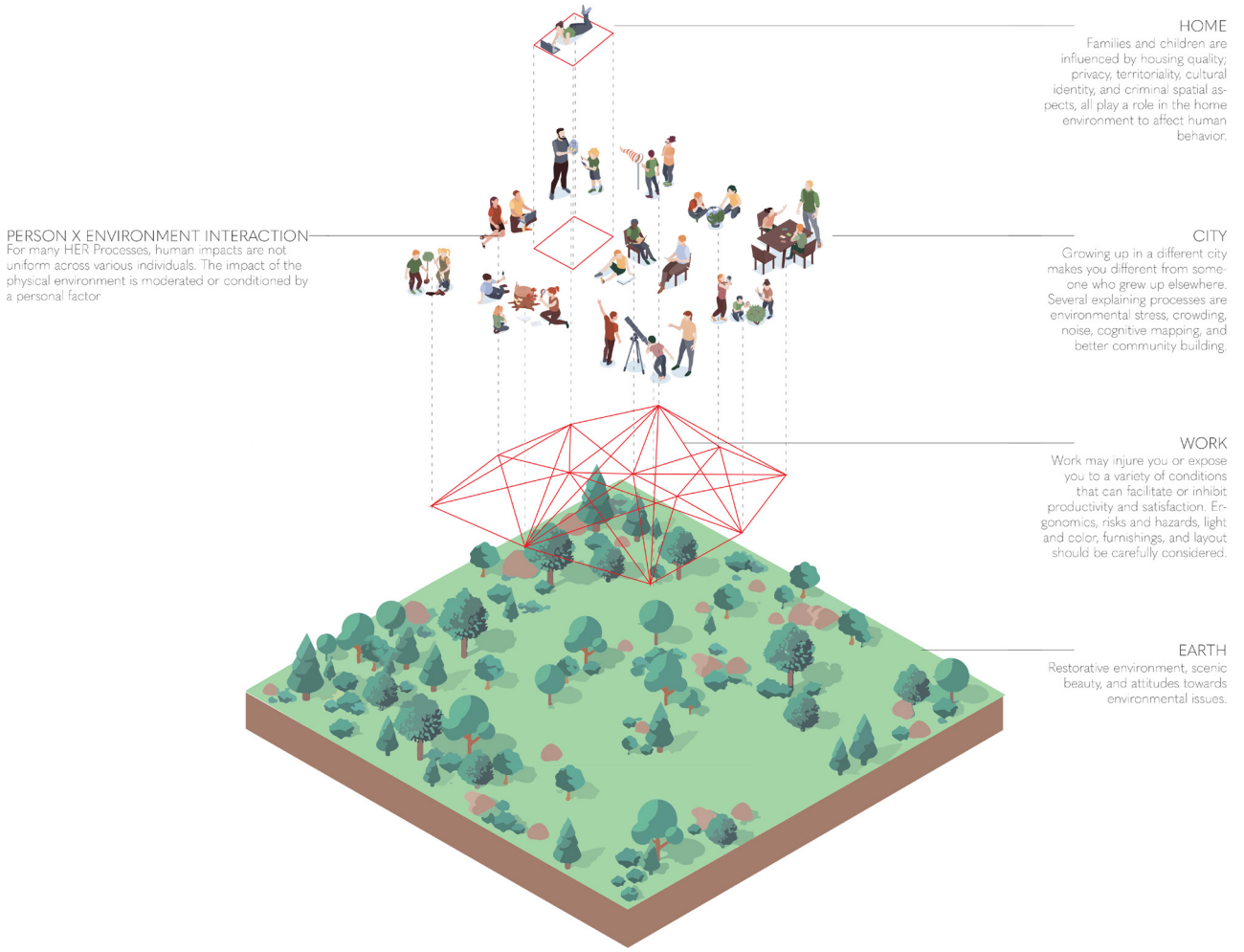
In the infographic assignments, students turned complex ideas into clear visual systems that rely on graphics rather than text. Many of these pieces later went into their final portfolios as evidence of their visual communication skills. Example student work from Fall 2023.



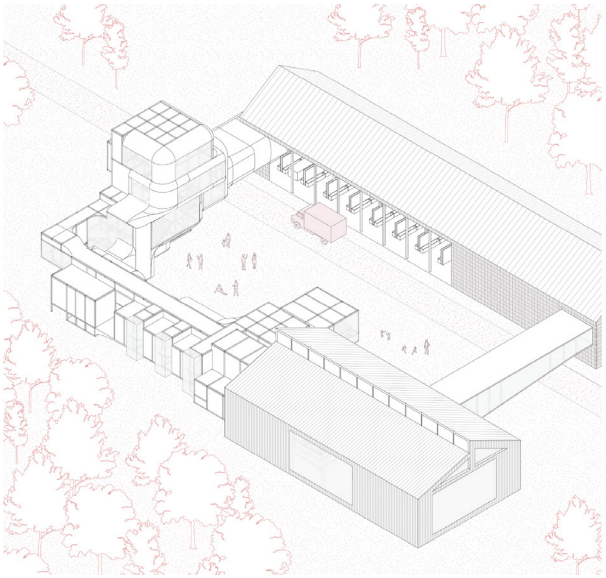
When discussing historical events, the portrayals of black history are consistently warped or left out entirely. Various states are currently introducing legislation to remove Black history from lesson plans. Brittney Cooper once said, "The idea that black people have had no impact on history, is one of the foundational ideas of white supremacy" (Cooper, 2019). It is essential to recognize that regardless of their oppression, marginalized communities do not have the simple luxury of letting go of the past. These oppressed groups are left to treat time like it is timeless.

Brittney Cooper discusses the concept of "space-takers" and "world-makers" throughout her work. Essentially, the white temporal imaginary allows white people to be the "world makers," and people of color are the "space takers." White people are considered the world makers, as they control time and the "flow and thrust" of history. This leaves black people being treated as if they are merely taking up space to which they are not entitled, forced to live between the lines of white history. White people are self-positioned as the masters of their time while marginalized communities are ruled by white time.

Everyone experiences time differently. A straight white male most likely understands time as a linear concept- he believes every day is new, and we are constantly progressing forward from the past. Someone who is African-American experiences time much differently. Marginalized communities all carry the weight of their history and trauma. Time does not feel linear for the black community because the "past and presents and futures seemingly coexist for African-American folks" (Cooper, 2019). Oppression, violence, and discrimination are all still very evident in our society today. A past filled with trauma is constantly being relived in the present.



In the infographic assignments, students turned complex ideas into clear visual systems that rely on graphics rather than text. Many of these pieces later went into their final portfolios as evidence of their visual communication skills. Example student work from Fall 2023.



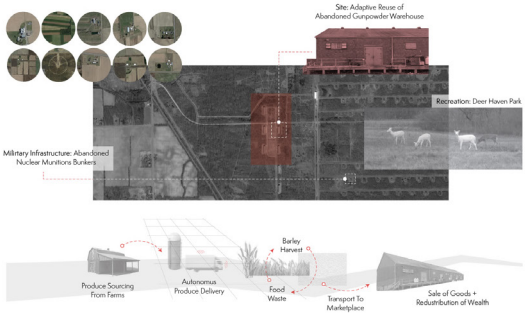
BREWERS ALLEY

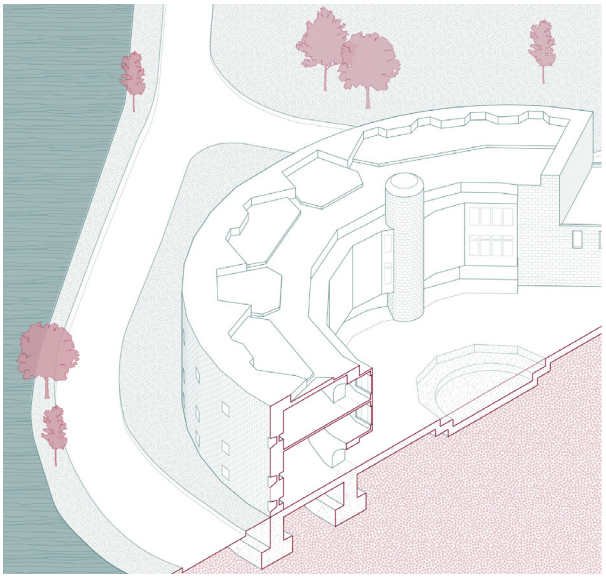
Witness to Production

Typology: Adaptive Reuse
Program: Brewery + Marketplace
Location: Seneca Army Depot, New York

In collaboration with Alexandra Ciobanu

The brewery seeks to bridge the divide between producer and consumer by utilizing the architecture of the brewery as an educational tool for beer drinkers to learn more about the brewing process. The project adaptively reuses abandoned military infrastructures to allow visitors to participate in the beer making process and witness nearly all stages involved in crafting the beverage, with distinct circulations for visitor and staff.





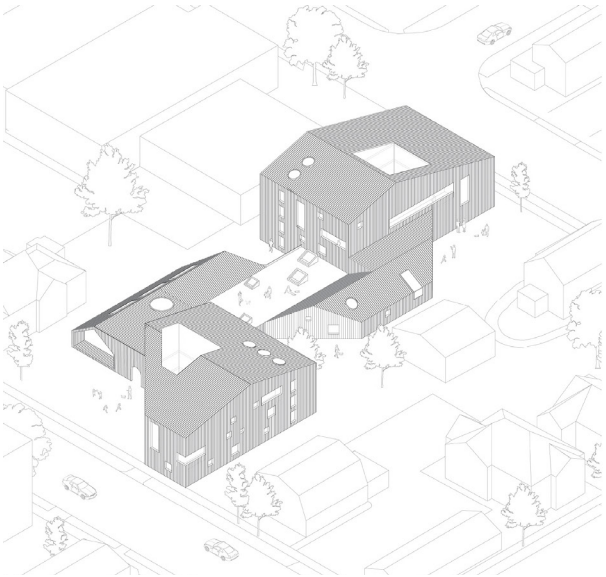
HEDONISTS PARADISE

Bathhouse of Pleasure

Typology: Adaptive Reuse
Program: Bathhouse
Location: Governors Island, New York City

The bathhouse seeks to converge the dichotomous legacy of war with the need for pleasure to reinvigorate the historical landscape. The project adaptively reuses Castle Williams, which once served as a prison for prisoners of war. The programs, which allude to notions of war, serve as a subtle reminder of the island's ominous history whilst providing comfort and joy to the bathers.



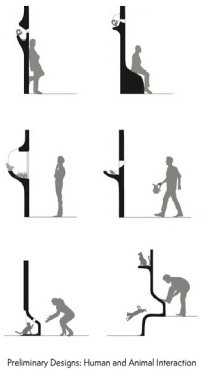


SANCTUARY

Human + Feline Housing

Typology: Mixed-Use
Program: Cat Rescue Center + Residental Housing
Location: Ithaca, New York

Located in the heart of downtown Ithaca between State and Green Street, the feline sanctuary offers an alternative mode of engagement and entertainment to the locals of the town and residents of the building. In addition to cats, the co-habitation complex is home rescue workers who rescue stray cats, as well as people who seek alternative companionship with feline friends.



Preliminary Designs: Human and Animal Interaction

Students designed each project introduction as part of the same visual and conceptual story, not as an isolated page. This final portfolio shows how the identity pages and project pages read as one coherent narrative. Example student work from Fall 2023.

DEA 5304

Cornell University

Fall 2023

Keywords:
Design Evaluation
Mixed Methods
Evidence-Based Design
Research Mentorship

Human Centered Design
Cornell Human Ecology

Design Accountability: Evaluation of the Physical Environment

Instructor: Mardelle Shepley

Teaching Assistant: **Mojtaba Ashour**

Design Accountability: Evaluation of the Physical Environment is a graduate seminar on evaluating buildings in use. Students learn research design, data collection, and analysis by studying real environments. In this offering, two student teams studied outpatient rehabilitation therapy spaces, gathering patient, staff, and designer perspectives on environmental features and comparing how important each feature seemed with how well it worked.

As teaching assistant for six students, I led the methods workshops, helped combine the two teams' work into one mixed-methods framework, and coached the group through interview and survey analysis, writing, and revision. The seminar's research became a peer-reviewed article in HERD: Health Environments Research & Design Journal (Shepley et al., 2026), with the students as co-authors. The article proposes topics for future design guidelines, and it gave the students a real path into scholarly publishing. It also shows that evaluation research in a classroom can feed back into practice, shaping the healthcare environments these students will later help design.

Research

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Mary Ann Liebert
A Part of Sage

Staff, Patient, and Designer Perspectives on Outpatient Rehabilitation Therapy Environments: A Pilot Study

Mardelle McCuskey Shepley, DArch[1], Karen Joyce, MS[1], Mojtaba Ashour, MSc[1], Nastaran Radmanesh, MA[1], Yifei Gao, MRP[2], Zeyu Liu, MS[1], Yi Cheng Shao, BS[1], and Jill Thai, BS[1]

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Abstract

Objectives: Recognizing the limited research and design guidelines for these essential health care settings, this study gathered pilot data on the design of outpatient rehabilitation therapy (RT) facilities as a foundation for future research.

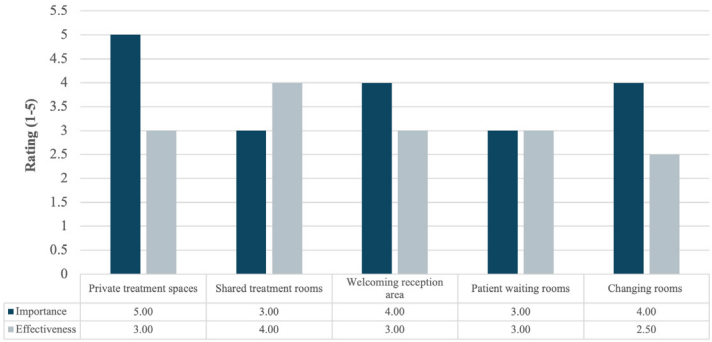
Background: Providing RT is core to addressing health conditions that might otherwise lead to higher and more costly levels of medical intervention. The World Health Organization estimates that 2.4 billion people worldwide would benefit from RT; however, only half receive care. As a result, more space may be sought for ambulatory clinics and hospital-based settings that cater to both inpatients and outpatients.

Methods: Interviews ($n = 21$) and questionnaires ($n = 43$) involving RT patients and staff and RT facility designers were conducted with overlap between the interview and questionnaire participants. Both methods explored amenities and features of RT environments.

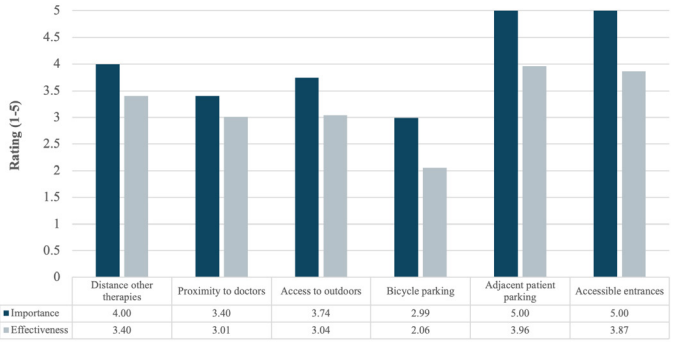
Results: Among the findings, there were several significant differences regarding the importance and effectiveness (presence) of specific environmental elements. Additionally, there were some significant differences among patients, staff, and designers in terms of their perceptions of importance and effectiveness.

Conclusion: Eight potential design guidelines are suggested, rather than recommended, as of yet. They are topics for future research and include the provision of an appropriate balance of private and shared spaces, acoustical treatment of open therapy areas, efficient and restorative staff areas, outdoor spaces, window views and daylight, flexible lighting, and appropriate furniture and wall coverings.

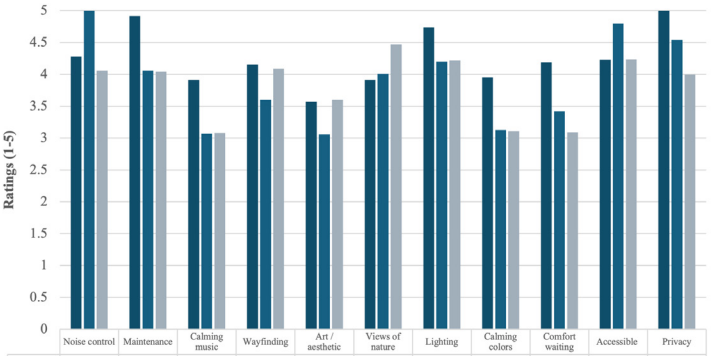
Published outcome of the graduate seminar.



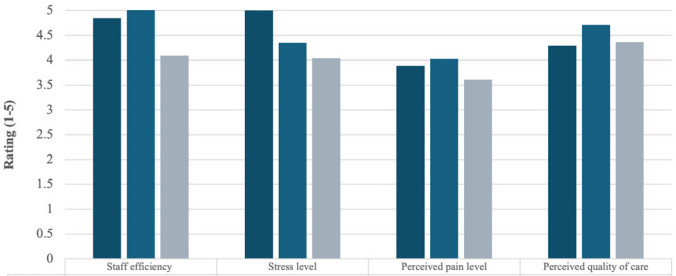
	Private treatment spaces	Shared treatment rooms	Welcoming reception area	Patient waiting rooms	Changing rooms
Importance	5.00	3.00	4.00	3.00	4.00
Effectiveness	3.00	4.00	3.00	3.00	2.50



	Distance other therapies	Proximity to doctors	Access to outdoors	Bicycle parking	Adjacent patient parking	Accessible entrances
Importance	4.00	3.40	3.74	2.99	5.00	5.00
Effectiveness	3.40	3.01	3.04	2.06	3.96	3.87



	Noise control	Maintenance	Calming music	Wayfinding	Art / aesthetic	Views of nature	Lighting	Calming colors	Comfort waiting	Accessible	Privacy
Patients	4.28	4.92	3.92	4.16	3.58	3.92	4.74	3.96	4.19	4.23	5.00
Staff	5.00	4.06	3.07	3.60	3.06	4.01	4.20	3.13	3.42	4.80	4.54
Designers	4.06	4.05	3.08	4.09	3.60	4.47	4.22	3.11	3.09	4.24	4.00



	Staff efficiency	Stress level	Perceived pain level	Perceived quality of care
Patients	4.85	5.00	3.89	4.29
Staff	5.00	4.35	4.03	4.72
Designers	4.09	4.04	3.61	4.36

Survey results from the student teams, comparing how patients, staff, and designers rated the importance of environmental features against how present and effective those features were in outpatient rehabilitation settings.

01 Private and open mix

Provide a mix of private treatment and open spaces for varied diagnoses, preferences, and cultural needs.

02 Acoustics and flexibility

Organize open therapy areas that are acoustically controlled, flexible, and positively distracting.

03 Multipurpose rooms

Provide multipurpose patient treatment rooms that can support changing care needs.

04 Staff work and respite

Support staff effectiveness and wellness with private work areas and restorative respite spaces.

05 Outdoor treatment

Incorporate protected outdoor treatment spaces for real-world and sport-specific therapy.

06 Daylight and lighting

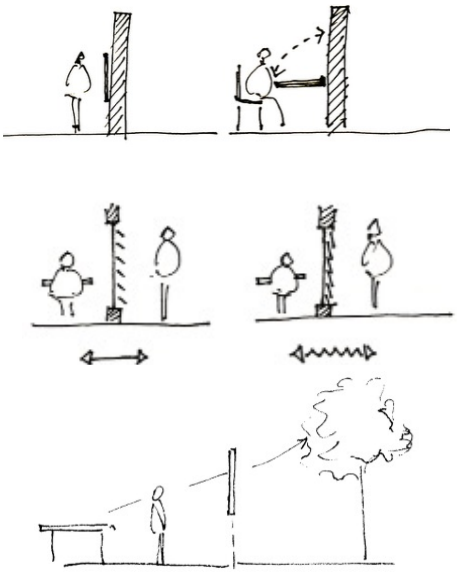
Provide daylighting plus ambient and task lighting for both patients and staff.

07 Ergonomic furniture

Specify furniture for patients at different rehabilitation stages and for staff providing care.

08 Walls and equipment

Organize equipment storage, motivational and safety messaging, and positive distraction on wall surfaces.



Eight potential design guidelines for outpatient rehabilitation environments, drawn from the interview and survey findings across patients, staff, and designers and proposed as topics for future research.